

Novelty Statement

Our paper addresses a fundamental question in biology: how do new ecologies and morphologies develop? The development of adaptive landscape thinking provided a way to cluster species into adaptive zones, but did not provide a pathway for how new regions of the landscape become populated. Our investigation suggests that transitions to new morphological and ecological spaces are facilitated by ecologically generalist and morphologically intermediate ancestors. Using new morphological and molecular datasets, we provide evidence of this pathway in Australian dragon lizards. This generalist-to-specialist transition provides a basis for how ecological opportunity can result in adaptive radiation, a central tenet of biodiversity research.



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Dear Prof. Akira S Mori,

We would like to begin by thanking both you and Reviewer 2 for additional creative and valuable thoughts. On behalf of myself and my coauthors, we appreciate your time and contributions.

All reviewers provided carefully considered comments and we have done our best to accommodate those suggestions here. The most significant changes include:

1. a new discrete trait analysis of substrate usage that improves upon previous approaches.
2. a more careful GLM modelling approach that provides greater insight into our claims of morphological intermediacy being linked to niche breadth.

We believe these additions substantially improve our argument and the quality of the manuscript.

Below please find **reviewer comments in green**, and our responses in black. New text added to the manuscript is **highlighted**. We have formatted a page break between editor and reviewer comments. Where necessary, we have interjected our responses among reviewer comments.

On behalf of myself and coauthors, we thank you for your time and consideration,

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Generalists link peaks in the shifting adaptive
landscape of Australia's dragon lizards

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Conceptualization, IGB, JSK, NC; sampling, LGT, JS; data collection ESB, JT, IGB; data
curation, IGB, ESB; methodology, NC, IGB; analysis IGB, ST; writing - original draft, IGB;
writing - reviewing & editing, all authors; funding acquisition, JSK.

Data Accessibility: All data and code are available on GitHub at
www.github.com/IanGBrennan/Amphibolurinae

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